Rescue from Hell

Narakoddhāra · Toh 1137 · Derge Tengyur

དམྱལ་བ་ནས་འདོན་པ།

Rescue from Hell, known in Sanskrit as the Narakoddhāri (rendered in the source as Narag Uddhari) and in Tibetan as Dmyal ba nas 'don pa, is a short devotional hymn of supplication. Opening with homage to the Protector of the World, it gives voice to a person sunk in the ocean of saṃsāra, abandoned by family and friends and left alone to face the consequences of past deeds, who repeatedly calls on the Tathāgata for protection. Through a series of vivid images, including a dark house, deep wells, bottomless oceans, and a boat with a broken hull, the verses convey helplessness and the longing for refuge in the Buddha's all-knowing compassion. The work is Toh 1137 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the collection of praises and devotional hymns.

In Sanskrit: narag uddhari nāma. In Tibetan: Rescue from Hell.

Homage to the Protector of the World.

In the great ocean of saṃsāra,
I am sunk in the mire of poverty.
Bring forth your all-knowing awareness:
O Tathāgata, protect me!

I have entered a house of darkness;
Without a protector, I endure suffering;
I have been abandoned by all my kin.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

Father and mother and sister,
Son and wife and women friends,
All like a conjured illusion, I am left cowering.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

For the sake of my circle of dependents here,
Whatever deeds I did, good or ill,
Because of them I am now alone.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

In great and terrible old wells
And in bottomless oceans,

Protector, when we have gone blind,
O Tathāgata, protect me!

Like a boat with a broken hull
Setting out to cross the great ocean,
I too cower, finding it hard to cross.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

Not knowing Dharma from what is not Dharma,
Not discerning the hard road from the road not to be taken,
This one is like a tree without a mind.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

Killing my father and killing my mother,
I have committed the five deeds of immediate retribution;
I cower in the darkness of terrible blindness.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

I have caused stupas to be destroyed;
I have plundered the property of the Saṅgha;
I have done harm to sentient beings.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

In this world there is no happiness for me;
The world beyond I have not come to know;
For I am bound by the threads of karma.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

The life of such a one is like this:
Like a kāśa flower in the sky,
Struck by the wind and drifting.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

In wilderness pastures and among
Many thorn trees offering no support,
There I did not see the path.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

Cattle that had done no wrong
And many wild beasts I killed with arrows,
And at that time I fancied myself a king.
O Tathāgata, protect me!

When beings are boiling in hell,
There is no protector at all.
To whom shall I go for refuge?
Who will be my protector?

King of physicians among physicians,
You who heal every disease,
Protector of the moving and the unmoving in the three realms,
You are the Protector of the World.

Rescue from Hell, composed by the great master Nāgārjuna, is complete.

Translator's Notes

• In the sixth stanza the text reads "rgal dkar," which yields no sense. It has been taken as a slip for "rgal dka'," meaning "hard to cross." "Protector of the World" (Lokanātha) is a common epithet of Avalokiteśvara, but the text does not name him, so the epithet has been kept as it stands.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.